

Political Factions in the Moonsea Empire

Imperialists: This faction is happy with things the way they are. They are loyal to the Stormlord and, although they may not all agree about who should be the next Stormlord, they support both the **Race Law** (prevents non-humans from ascending to the throne) and the **Storm Law** (mandating that only those descended from Edric Storm may ascend to the throne) as important to the stability and prosperity of the Moonsea Empire.

Imperialists are, by far, the largest and most vocal and well-known faction. It is safest, when chatting with someone you don't know, to claim to be an Imperialist. Then again, many people claim to be Imperialists who are secretly aligned with a different faction. For obvious reasons, the Imperialists are unlikely to want or need to form alliances with any other faction.

Militarists: This faction believes that Moonsea should be ruled by a strong military leader, all the better to abandon its much-vaunted neutrality and use its considerable might to engage in territorial expansion. This faction seeks to overturn the **Sword Law** that prevents any one who has ever served as High Stormreaver from ascending to the throne. Many Militarists also want to overturn the **Storm Law**, because they want High Stormreaver Maxillar Buel (who has no Storm lineage) to be the first leader of the Moonsea military to assume the office of Stormlord. Only if the current Stormlord were ever to die or abdicate, of course!

The second most prolific faction, the Militarists have gained widespread support over the last decade, as Maxillar Buel has breathed new vigor and vitality in the Stormreavers, Moonsea's powerful military. Buel is popular and fabulously wealthy, largely as a result of defeating the neighboring nation of Vaas, during its attempted invasion of the Moonsea Empire in 195 AZ. This wealth enables him to shower his allies with favor and bribes.

The Militarists believe in the imperial model and have no interest in dethroning Edric III, so they can sometimes align with the Imperialists. But the Militarists do want some changes, which can put them at odds with the Imperialists. On the other hand, the Militarists are only too happy to ally with the Reformers, whose zeal for change can be useful. Militarists are less likely to work with the Republicans or Seccessionists, for obvious reasons.

Reformers: This faction wants to "improve" the Empire, pushing changes that will lead to a more open and enlightened Moonsea. They seek to eliminate the restriction against non-humans ascending to the office of Stormlord (**Race Law**), to reduce the Moonsea's role as the world's foremost arms traders, and even to free the enslaved orcs of Xul Jurak. Trust me, they have LOTS of other reforms they'd love to tell you about, if you have time.

The Reformers are made up of equal parts self-loathing rich nobles and rabble rousers from the lower classes. They oppose the Imperialists to the extent they want to broaden the pool of potential Stormlords and they are wary of the Militarists, because they are against wars of expansion and they chafe at the Empire's heavy involvement in global weapons sales. The Reformers are willing to form temporary alliances with the Republicans and Seccessionists toward certain limited goals - these factions share a desire for change, after all.

Republicans: This faction is devoted to the end of the Empire, pushing instead for a Republic, led by the Senate and a Consul elected every two years. This faction will wax poetic about the virtues of republican rule, and how the *hoi polloi* need representatives from among the aristocracy, not an all-powerful dictator, to help guide this great nation.

Not surprisingly, many Senators are a part of this faction, some openly and others only in secret. They see the Reformers as natural allies, because they believe once you allow the idea of things being different from how they currently are, then all bets are off and who knows where that will lead. They will also team up with the Secessionists, because both want to push for the end of the Stormlord's rule. Obviously, the Republicans are staunchly opposed to the Imperialists and the Militarists.

Secessionists: This faction is devoted to the end of the Empire and a return to the time before Edric Storm declared himself "Stormlord of the Moonsea". This faction comprises nobles who wish to rule over their city-states, provinces, or whatever entity they were before being absorbed by the Empire.

This faction finds its strongest foothold in the city of Mulmaster, which had been the most powerful city in the Moonsea region before Edric Storm founded his empire. The further one is from Melvaunt, the more likely one is to find support for this faction. Melvaunt enjoys being the capitol of an empire, making the Secessionists very unpopular in the city. They can form alliances with the Reformers and Republicans, but view the Militarists as almost as bad as the Imperialists.